As a culture that was already an empire in the sixth century BCE, and then again from the seventh century until the Khomeini revolution in 1979, Iran does not recognize or accept the Western concept of “time being of the essence.” As noted earlier, when it comes to achieving a goal through negotiations, there is no match for the Persian. He has immeasurably more patience than the American, who has a history of only two hundred years—thus my prediction that the Iranians will exhaust the Americans and their allies and squeeze more and more concessions out of them. In the course of time, they will fulfill their part of the agreement, first of all until the sanctions are lifted and their relations with the West return to normal. Down the road, the world will have to deal with problems and crises as they arise. Presidents and heads of state will change, and the Iranians will begin to chip away at the agreement, gradually and with small steps, none of which will cross any of the lines set out by the West. At a point in time that suits them—perhaps at the time of the agreement’s expiration, but it is certainly possible that it will happen earlier—they will declare themselves a nuclear state. At that moment, they will have realized their first goal of achieving immunity and will set out to achieve their second goal—making Iran a regional power—in a much more determined and brazen way.

At this point, when the world will have to treat Iran as a country with nuclear capability, it will have to grapple with the million-dollar question: Will a nuclear Iran act as a pragmatic state or as a messianic state? This question is not theoretical at all. One mustn’t forget that the person with his finger on the nuclear trigger is the spiritual leader, who speaks the word of Allah and is therefore infallible. It should also be remembered that the Shia does not recognize coexistence with anyone other than Shiites and that the realization of the caliphate, the supreme and ultimate goal of Shiite faith, sanctifies a jihad against the infidels.

The question posed in the simplistic form of “messianic versus pragmatic” does not reflect the subtleties of the dilemma. When Iran becomes a member of the club of nuclear states, the situation will be fundamentally different from what it was during the Cold War, when the global order was dictated by two nuclear blocs that created a system of tools and capabilities that ensured stability and the prevention of errors. In a system of nuclear states between whom there is no symmetry, who have different interests, and for some of whom the well-being of the human race is not a priority, all it takes is one provocation that party A sees as tolerable